FOR PARENTS · SUPPORTING YOUR YOUNG PLAYER

CONFIDENCE & SELF-TALK

Quietening the inner critic

16

THE QUICK VERSION

> Every player has a voice in their head. After a mistake, it can say "You're hopeless" or it can say "Next ball." Kids aren't born knowing how to talk to themselves kindly, but it's a skill they can learn, and you can help them practise it.

WHAT'S REALLY GOING ON

Confidence isn't about never making mistakes. It's about trusting yourself to handle them. Children often pick up their inner voice from the adults around them, so the way we talk to them (and about ourselves) slowly becomes the way they talk to themselves on the pitch.

TURN THE INNER CRITIC INTO AN INNER COACH

INNER COACH

- ✓ "Next ball."
- ✓ "I'm still learning this."
- ✓ "I've done this before, I can do it again."
- ✓ "One mistake doesn't define my game."

INNER CRITIC

- × "I'm so bad."
- × "I always mess up."
- × "Everyone thinks I'm terrible."
- × "I should just give up."

THE RESET ROUTINE

1

NOTICE

Catch the critic: "What did you say to yourself after that mistake?"

2

SWAP

Choose a coach phrase together, like "Next ball" or "Stay strong."

3

PRACTISE

Use it at home, at school and in training until it becomes automatic.

TRY THIS

1 Ask about their inner voice
"What do you say to yourself when things go wrong?" You might be surprised.

2 Build a confidence bank
Write down three things they did well after each game and reread them before the next.

3 Watch your own self-talk
If you say "I'm hopeless at this" about yourself, they hear it.

4 Use a physical reset
A clap, a deep breath or touching their shin pad can signal "move on."

5 Celebrate small wins
Confidence is built one good moment at a time.

SAY THIS, NOT THAT

SAY THIS	NOT THAT
"What would you say to a teammate who did that?"	~~"Why are you so hard on yourself?"~~
"Mistakes are part of learning."	~~"You should be better than that."~~
"Remember that great pass you made?"	~~"Stop being so negative."~~

QUICK SELF-CHECK

- [ ] I know what my child says to themselves after mistakes
- [ ] We've chosen a reset phrase together
- [ ] I watch how I talk about myself
- [ ] We celebrate small wins, not just big ones

Can't tick them all yet? That's normal. Pick one to work on this week.

COACH'S CORNER

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The most confident players aren't the ones who never mess up. They're the ones who've learned to say "next ball" and mean it.

THE FUTURE BALLER TEAM